

“Everything Was Real; Inconceivably Real, Infinitely Dear”:

Liminal Underworlds and Quantum Love

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The elevator doors slam with a metallic clang that jolts me. I watch the red-lit numbers ascend slowly to 7M, the top floor of the Sterling Memorial Library stacks. As each number blips up, I cannot help but think of how many books I have just passed on each level, the insurmountable human knowledge of which I will never know more than a mere fraction. The man-made ascent machine slows to a halt, dipping slightly, but I'm not worried. How advanced humans are, I think, to have somehow created iron-woven cables capable of lifting even an elephant to new heights. I wonder whether an elephant has ever been in an elevator. What must it have thought when its vertical sense of the world changed in an instant? Perhaps that it had ascended to elephant heaven.

I look down at my scribbles of the location of the books I aim to find. Take the elevator to the 7M floor, turn to the left and keep walking until the far window, then a right to the last bookshelf in the row. Fitting, somehow, that the books about death should be on the very top floor of the stacks, on the farthest shelf. At least I haven't descended to subterranean Bass. I survey the titles before me. *Spirit in Ashes*. *What Dreams May Come*. *The Hour of Our Death*. *The Eternal Pity*. What a cheery way to spend my senior year.

I first began to explore these questions in Toni Dorfman's brilliant class on "Representations of the Underworld," where my final paper centered on George Saunders's *Lincoln in the Bardo*. That essay concluded with the lines:

To live, after all, is to dwell in the space between two unknowables: birth and death. I am always in motion, never collapsed, suspended in the Bardo of life. After all, what is suspension but a form of faith?¹

That suspension between unknowables is also, I think, the condition of humanistic inquiry. In this thesis, I've expanded on the conceptualization of that final paper and stayed in company

¹ Elizabeth Schaefer, "Inconceivably Real, Infinitely Dear," 9. 2025.

with Saunders because my initial questions about the true underworld opened only onto a series of new thresholds. I ride upward through floor after floor of books I will never fully know, held buoyant by trusting a mechanism I cannot explain. I have learned well at Yale that the work of the humanities is not to banish the unknowable, but to instead learn to find insight in the margins of such mystery.

On March 21st, I took the Amtrak Northeast Regional straight to the Bardo. That is, I visited Oak Hill Cemetery in Washington, D.C., the graveyard where Abraham Lincoln's son, Willie, was first buried and the setting of *Lincoln in the Bardo*. The cemetery was beautiful. It was the first true spring day, and the new sunlight shone upon the winding hills studded with flowering trees. Skeletons were laid below the soft green grass. Skeletons still lie below. Even now as I write this, past and present tense get confusing when it comes to relations between the dead and the living.

On that day, I slowly meandered through the sun-dappled rows of tombstones on my quest to find Willie's borrowed crypt, my dog-eared copy of *Lincoln in the Bardo* self-consciously clenched in my hands. I noted the words that people or their loved ones had chosen to carefully etch on their graves. All throughout my humanities major, I have clung to similar words. Poetry. Fiction. How beautiful is it that we string the syllables to become the words to become the sentences that manifest murmurs from our hearts. Mary L. Chapin's tombstone quotes Tennyson's "Crossing the Bar;" she is hence forever "sunset and evening star."² Many graves only show the deceased's name and the range of dates, their inhabitants memorialized only by their corporeal beginning and end, leaving the viewer left to envision the soul suspended in between those two bookends. Each one could have been anyone. I spied one

² Lord Alfred Tennyson, "Crossing the Bar," *Poetry Foundation*.
<https://www.poetryfoundation.org/poems/45321/crossing-the-bar>.

such grave bearing only these names and dates, but it memorializes one dead soul and one living: Dave Keith Haworth, 1924-2023, and Karen Friedmann Beall, 1938-. How moving that she loved him enough to place herself beside him before her own time had come, to caress the world of the dead from that of the living.

As I approached the line of crypts at the end of the cemetery, the atmosphere shifted. I passed one such crypt with a brown wreath placed over the gate. I paused and saw an invoice slip on it, addressed to *Richard Wallach, Oak Hill Cemetery, 3001 R ST NW, Plot 286*, which declared a “card enclosed.” Poignantly, Mr. Wallach himself was the inhabitant of the crypt and the recipient of this wreath and card. This realm of the cemetery was more dilapidated than the neat landscaping by the entrance gate. Nearby, pallets of wood and blue tarps lay beside scaffolding around an old monument-esque structure, a jolting manmade eyesore compared to the weathered stone of the surrounding tombstones and towering oaks. And yet, even amongst the debris of an apparent Home Depot aisle, I found myself touched by how much we living care for the dead: to keep repairing what eventually decays; to address wreaths and cards to those who can no longer answer; to write (or read) a miraculous novel set here, where all Oak Hill residents can still live forever in fiction.

Yet even there, among the poetry verses, decrepit wreaths, and stone glossed by caressing hands, I kept returning to the same question: what does it mean to look at the dead at all? Does it mean we really see them? A grave asks to be read, just as a book does by the girl clutching it as she wanders a cemetery, searching in both text and stone for some answer to the primordial question. A tombstone invites the living to imagine that these earthly remainders might stand in for a whole life, but the dead resist that kind of easy legibility. They linger at the edge of definition, suspended between what can be known and what cannot. Again and again, the texts

that shape this thesis return to that unstable interval, and to the powerful urge by the living to collapse that instability by forcing the soul into a single readable form.

Observational Collapse

Jonathan Edwards's "Sinners in the Hands of an Angry God" imagines the sinner in a precarious state, suspended above Hell but never securely separated from it. In his fiery sermon, Edwards insists that "There is nothing that keeps wicked Men at any one Moment, out of Hell, but the meer Pleasure of GOD," and later sharpens that danger by warning that "'tis nothing but his Hand that holds you from falling into the Fire every Moment."³ The sinner is therefore neither fully safe amongst the living nor yet fully fixed amongst the damned. Edwards particularly underscores this unstable gap when he contrasts his alive listeners with those already dead and condemned: "Their Case is past all Hope... but here you are in the Land of the Living."⁴ The damned have already been assigned a final state; the living sinner has not. He or she remains poised between salvation and destruction, inhabiting a liminal condition of terrifying uncertainty.

This logic resembles the thought experiment of Schrödinger's cat, in which a cat sealed inside a box is linked to an uncertain quantum event.⁵ Until the box is opened and the cat is actually observed, the cat exists in a quantum superposition of states, *both alive and dead at once*. The point of the thought experiment is not a simple probability between two outcomes, but the literal coexistence of multiple realities. The cat occupies an unresolved state that becomes singular only when an observer opens the box and demands an answer. It is the act of observation

³ Jonathan Edwards, "Sinners in the Hands of an Angry God: A Sermon Preached at Enfield, July 8th, 1741," ed. Reiner Smolinski, *Electronic Texts in American Studies*, University of Nebraska-Lincoln, 5-15.

⁴ *Ibid.*, 23

⁵ Erwin Schrödinger, "Die gegenwärtige Situation in der Quantenmechanik (The Present Situation in Quantum Mechanics)," *Naturwissenschaften* 23 (48), November 1935: 807-812.

that forces uncertainty into a single result, hence destroying that precious liminal world where many existences are still possible. Edwards's sinner is imagined in much the same way: not yet in Hell, but never safely outside it either, "every Moment" liable to fall, for their "foot shall slide in due Time."⁶ His depiction of divine judgment functions as the very moment of existential collapse through a form of scrutiny, the instant at which suspended possibility is forced into one final and legible postmortem reality.

This dynamic is what I would term *observational collapse*: the urge to compress a liminal, contradictory, or still-unfolding being into a single readable outcome. In Edwards's sermon, God's gaze will not ultimately permit ambiguity to endure. At any moment, the unstable soul may be rendered fully knowable as damned. This concept of observational collapse extends beyond Edwards. It names not only divine judgment, but a broader literary and metaphysical impulse: the desire to resolve beings who remain in suspension. Whether it is the liminal souls in the Bardo, grey Hell-town, or *Purgatorio*, their final state is fixed through a combination of creative intention and the examination of the reader.

Divine Judgment

To confront death is always, in some sense, to confront the limits of perception itself. As Peter Koestenbaum notes, the death of another can still be understood as an event "in the world," because the observing self remains intact to witness it.⁷ My own death, however, poses a more radical problem: I cannot truly imagine my own nonexistence, because the very act of imagining it restores me as the spectator in action. Freud makes a similar point when he writes that whenever we attempt to imagine our own death, "we survive as spectators."⁸ Death therefore

⁶ Ibid., 3-4

⁷ *The Eternal Pity: Reflections on Dying*, edited by Richard John Neuhaus, University of Notre Dame Press, 2000, 8.

⁸ Ibid., 7

resists personal representation not only because it ends life, but because it abolishes the observer through whom the world appears at all. As Koestenbaum further puts it, “my image of the death of myself is tantamount to asserting the end of the world.”⁹ There is no consolation for the end of the world; perhaps this is why cultural and religious imagination returns so insistently to scenes of final judgment. These emphatic scenes externalize that unimaginable ending, transforming the private impossibility of one’s own death into a collective spectacle of absolute conclusion – which, usually, ends in heavenly justification and glory for the perceiver based on their divine judgment framework of choice. Depictions of final judgment offer clarity and visualization, a luxury that death itself withholds. It promises that the disappearance of the self can still be answered by a stable verdict, that the dead can be fully known and resolved. We desire, on a cosmic scale, for the catastrophe implied by our own death to be properly recognized, to be fully visualized and understood as the end of the world as we *can* know it.

Michelangelo’s *Last Judgment* (Figure 1) monumentalizes that desire. The fresco is organized around the spectacle of final sorting, as souls are lifted upward or cast downward according to God’s absolute verdict. Scenes such as this attract immense religious and artistic attention, not just for the skill of their craft, but also because they offer the fantasy of complete interpretation, a divine time machine. The soul is made legible through judgment, sorted into a stable category that resolves the uncertainty of what comes after. The fresco’s setting also matters here. Created and displayed in the Sistine Chapel, at the center of ecclesiastical authority, *The Last Judgment* was likely addressed less to the ‘damned’ than to those who expected to stand among the saved. Unlike Edwards’s sermon, which works by terrifying listeners with the possibility of their own condemnation, Michelangelo’s fresco offers a vision of judgment from

⁹ Ibid., 8

within the institutional world that authorizes it. For the Christian viewer, the fresco can provide comfort through identification with the saved, while also granting a sense of power by placing ideological opponents among the damned. In this sense, *The Last Judgment* gives visual form to the very longing described above: the wish that death's unknowability might be overcome by a final scene in which the curtain is pulled back and everything is at last made clear, with one's place in a better world assured.



Figure 1: Michelangelo's *The Last Judgment*¹⁰

¹⁰ Michelangelo, *The Last Judgment*. 1536-1541, Sistine Chapel, Vatican City. *Wikimedia Commons*, [https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Last_Judgement_\(Michelangelo\).jpg](https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Last_Judgement_(Michelangelo).jpg).

Yet even these famous binaries depend upon a prior state that receives far less attention. In the lower right corner of Michelangelo's fresco, where damned souls cling to Charon's boat and oars, these figures have not yet fully settled into the clarity of their final designation (Figure 2). They cling to that threshold, as if resisting not only punishment but the finality of having been decisively placed. What emerges here is the possibility that the most charged space in the afterlife is not the repercussion of classification itself, but the interval just before it: the liminal condition in which the soul remains unresolved. In this sense, these tragic figures recall Edwards's insistence that his listeners remain fortunate simply to be in "the Land of the Living," where repentance is still possible and judgment has not yet closed, where God's hand has not yet acted.¹¹ Michelangelo's sinners seem to not only resist their punishment, but the loss of their state of quantum superposition. The moment beyond this state is when all remaining ambiguity is collapsed into singularity by a divine judgment into the dreaded binary of damned and saved. If cultural and religious imagination so often fixes its gaze on this drama of final binary judgment, George Saunders's *Lincoln in the Bardo* turns instead to that underexamined interval, lingering among the dead precisely where endings have not yet hardened into certainty.

¹¹ Edwards, "Sinners in the Hands of an Angry God," 23.



Figure 2: Michelangelo's *The Last Judgment*¹²

George Saunders's *Lincoln in the Bardo* was published in 2017, his first full-length novel and the winner of that year's Booker Prize.¹³ An important and unique feature of the novel is that it primarily focuses on the bardo, a concept from Tibetan Buddhism that is defined as "the period between the time of death and the time of rebirth." This bardo can be further broken up into even more intermediary states, such as the intermediate state of living (rang-bzhin bardo), the intermediate state of dreaming (rmi-lam bardo), and the intermediate state of rebirth (srid-pa'i bardo).¹⁴ Saunders adapts that framework into an American, Civil War-era setting, imagining a chorus of dead voices gathered in Georgetown's Oak Hill Cemetery on the night after young Willie Lincoln's death. It is based upon historical reports of Abraham Lincoln's visits to his son's crypt amidst overwhelming grief, and the novel even uses historical quotations to frame its fictional dead.

¹² Ibid.

¹³ George Saunders, *Lincoln in the Bardo* (New York: Random House, 2017).

¹⁴ *The Tibetan Book of the Dead: First Complete Translation; The Great Liberation by Hearing in the Intermediate States*. Composed by Padmasambhava, revealed by Tertön Karma Lingpa, translated by Gyurme Dorje, edited by Graham Coleman with Thupten Jinpa, introductory commentary by His Holiness the Dalai Lama, Penguin Books, 479.

Within the cemetery, after any visitors have departed for their bustling, living world, the dead come out at night into their own society. This is Saunders's Bardo, where the souls lingering within do not yet realize they have died. Instead, they wait to enact whatever lingering presence they had still hoped to have on earth, to resolve unfinished business, and to wait for their families and loved ones to come back to them. They are in a sort of *rmi-lam bardo*, not awake to their current state, and where dreaming is transmuted to the sort of soporific flux that can only exist at night, the realm of the dead but not departed. Although *Lincoln in the Bardo* is primarily rooted in this transitory setting, there is one distinct scene that hints at the beyond, a parallel to *The Last Judgment*. Reverend Everly Thomas is a Christian preacher who believes he lived morally and in service to his God. He has faith in his good nature and willingly leaves the Bardo almost instantaneously after his death, afterwards finding himself in a scene of divine judgment. He witnesses his companions being judged and sorted by a Christ-like arbitrator and his accompanying angelic beings, and in doing so beholds the two drastically opposing fates that await them. One man is deemed worthy, and enters "a tent of purest white silk" containing "a magnificent king," and next to the king, "an empty chair... upholstered with gold, if gold were spun of light and each particle of that light exuded joy and the sound of joy."¹⁵ In contrast, his other companion is forced into a tent of flesh, "speckled and pink with spoiled blood," with a "bloody-handed and long-fanged" beast presiding over a "flaying table."¹⁶ The Reverend notes the "bitter contrast between happiness... and sadness" post-judgment in this divine binary.¹⁷

The tools used to determine fate in this scene of divine judgment are particularly telling. The two angelic beings present a mirror and a scale to their subject. The person's appearance is examined in the mirror, and their heart is weighed on the scale, both mechanisms that claim

¹⁵ Ibid., 190.

¹⁶ Ibid., 190-191

¹⁷ Ibid., 190

objectivity through measurement. However, even these seemingly impartial tools are already marked by bias. Those assigned to the heavenly tent are reflected in a mirror “encrusted with precious gems,” while those fated for the monstrous tent must see themselves in a “feces-encrusted mirror.”¹⁸ Observation here is never neutral; it is already saturated with moral assumptions. The potential to transmute into either final state in this “measuring” scene is in fact only a farce. This underworld, like so many systems of judgment, claims neutrality while operating far from it. A similar example drawn from classical divine judgment lies in ancient Egyptian mythology. After death, the deceased appear in a hall of judgment where their heart is placed on a balancing scale, similar to the Reverend’s vision.¹⁹ Their heart is weighed against the feather of Maat, which is an ostrich feather associated with the eponymous ancient Egyptian goddess and her corresponding principle of truth, justice, and cosmic order.²⁰ If the deceased lived in accordance with Maat, then their heart would be lighter than the feather and they would ascend to a blessed afterlife with Osiris. If not, then the Egyptian goddess Ammit, depicted as an amalgamation of different beasts, would devour their heart.²¹ A heart impossibly lighter than a feather, a mirror already covered with feces before reflection has even begun... such imagery reveals that absolute judgment is never merely the neutral manifestation of what the soul already is. Rather, it is a theatrical process that attempts to convert moral complexity into a legible visual verdict. In both Saunders’s vignette and the Egyptian hall of judgment, the soul appears in front of the judicial bench only in order to be interpreted and fixed on predetermined terms. The very tools that claim to discover moral truth instead dramatize the prior commitment to the

¹⁸ Ibid., 189-191

¹⁹ Denise Martin, “Maat and Order in African Cosmology: A Conceptual Tool for Understanding Indigenous Knowledge,” *Journal of Black Studies* 38, no. 6 (2008): 951-67, JSTOR: 960.

²⁰ Ibid., 951

²¹ Ibid., 960

observational reduction of liminality. Judgment thus becomes a kind of observational collapse: the soul, once ambiguous, is unduly forced into permanent meaning.

Excessive Love

If observational collapse names the impulse to render the dead fully legible, then its most sympathetic perpetrator is love. In *Lincoln in the Bardo*, the desire to see and hold the dead does not begin in judgment, but in grief through Lincoln's repeated return to Willie's body. Initially, Willie witnesses the unfortunate state of Elise Traynor, who is trapped by tendrils against the Bardo's iron fence, a side effect of her "tarrying" in the Bardo. Hans Vollman and Roger Bevins III are able to convince Willie to leave the Bardo, to go beyond, for there is "nothing left for [him] here."²² Yet at the very moment Willie begins to depart, his beloved father's arrival interrupts that movement beyond. Mr. Lincoln appears before Willie's white stone vault, and Willie is drawn to his father, abandoning his attempt at moving beyond the Bardo. Mr. Lincoln removes and opens Willie's coffin, "sick-box," from the wall, letting out a "gasp of recognition," as if to say, "Here he is again, my child, just as he was. I have found him again, he who was so dear to me."²³ Mr. Lincoln proceeds to pick up Willie's corpse from the coffin and cradle him in his arms, speaking sweetly to him. Willie, meanwhile, finds it agonizing to witness his father's grief, complaining that "no matter how I patted & kissed & made to console" it did no good.²⁴

As he gently holds and whispers to Willie's dead body, Mr. Lincoln internally questions whether this return to the corpse is right:

The feel of him in my arms has done me good. It has. Is this wrong? Unholy? No, no, he is mine, he is ours, and therefore I must be, in that sense, a god in this; where he is concerned I may decide what is best. And I believe this has done me good. I remember him. Again.²⁵

²² Saunders, *Lincoln in the Bardo*, 41.

²³ Ibid., 47

²⁴ Ibid., 61

²⁵ Ibid., 61

This passage is especially striking because Lincoln explicitly links love to divine authority. In claiming that Willie is “mine,” he transforms grief into a kind of interpretive possession: because Willie belonged to him in life, Lincoln still feels entitled to determine what is “best” for him even in death. The language is tender and loving, but it is also possessive. Lincoln does not merely mourn Willie; he asserts a right to recover and define him. When he leaves the crypt, he promises, “Dear boy... I will come again. That is a promise.”²⁶ That promise is loving, but it is also what keeps Willie trapped in the Bardo, a suspension that the reader has already graphically seen can be extremely dangerous. In this way, Saunders suggests that love can become a dangerous anchor. The desire to preserve the beloved may keep both the living and the dead bound to an impossible nearness that in fact hinders growth for them both.

Saunders is not alone in imagining love as a force that cannot relinquish visual confirmation. In the myth of Orpheus and Eurydice, love likewise becomes inseparable from the urge to look, to verify, to make the beloved present to sight one final time. Orpheus’s backward glance is often read as doubt, but it can also be understood as grief’s refusal to tolerate ambiguity. He cannot endure Eurydice as a presence that is real yet not fully visible, near yet not yet restored. In this sense, his love produces its own form of observational collapse: rather than trusting in her gradual return, he turns to see her, and in doing so fixes her loss irrevocably.

Rainer Maria Rilke versifies this quite beautifully in “Orpheus. Eurydice. Hermes:”

She was within herself, like one of higher hope,
and did not think of the man, who went ahead,
nor of the path, which rose up into life.

She was within herself...

Already she was no longer the blond woman

²⁶ Ibid., 62

who had sometimes echoed in the poet's songs,
 no longer the wide bed's scent and isle
 and that man's property no more...
 She was already root.²⁷

"Orpheus. Eurydice. Hermes" makes Orpheus's backward glance even more devastating by showing that Eurydice is already no longer the woman he hopes to recover. She is "within herself," cut off from both Orpheus and the road back to life, and "that man's property no more." By the poem's end, she is "already root," transformed beyond the language of human attachment. She can no longer be fully defined through corporeal relationships, because her definition now belongs to a larger cosmic vocabulary that exceeds them both. Orpheus's glance, then, is not only an act of doubt but an act of flawed reclamation, a protestation against the natural fate of mortals. Here, Rilke's poem meets with Lincoln's possessive claim that Willie is "mine." Both Orpheus and Lincoln meet the dead at the moment they are becoming otherwise, and both respond by trying to recover them in the terms of former love. To look back, to open the coffin, to insist on the child "just as he was"... these are all attempts to resist the dead person's transformation by insisting upon making them visible and familiar once more. In this way, love becomes observational collapse, fixing the beloved in the static, entrapping image the mourner cannot relinquish.

While Lincoln's and Orpheus's grief shows how love can become an anchor, *Lincoln in the Bardo* also imagines another form of love, one that does not bind the dead more tightly to the world they have left, but helps them move beyond it. Saunders populates the Bardo with emissaries who come for the dead to convince them to move on, beyond the Bardo into whatever awaits them. These figures appear angelic and of otherworldly beauty, often taking the shape of

²⁷ Rainer Maria Rilke, "Orpheus. Eurydice. Hermes," translated by Peter Joseph Belfiore, Oxford University Press, 2007, lines 60-64, 76-80, 84.

loved ones, suggesting that passage beyond the Bardo is mediated not by abstract judgment alone, but by the familiar language of human love. For Willie, these figures come in the most instinctive form of nurturing love for a child, as apparitions of his mother: “All of those Mothers loved me so and wanted me to go with and said they would take me home soon as I was ready.”²⁸ Unlike Lincoln’s return to the crypt, which seeks Willie in the form he once had, these apparitions do not try to preserve him unchanged or restore him to his old life. Instead, they present departure in the form of love, making it possible for the soul to move toward a new horizon that would otherwise be unbearable. Saunders thus distinguishes between two kinds of love: one that clings to the beloved’s earthly form, and another that helps release the beloved from it. The images of mothers, daughters, sons, and ex-fiancées who appear before the dead are effective not because they are literally the loved ones themselves, but because they allow the soul to encounter transformation through viscerally recognizable terms of love.

A similar dynamic appears in C. S. Lewis’s *The Great Divorce*, where the bright figures who appear before the visitors from the grey Hell-town are not abstract angels feigning a familiar appearance, but rather their true transformed loved ones.²⁹ Having surrendered the vices and attachments that once governed them, they now serve as emissaries to convert those still trapped in pride, resentment, and self-enclosure. Their role is not to drag souls backward into old relationships, but to invite them forward into a condition those relationships could never fully sustain on earth. In both Lewis and Saunders, then, love becomes redemptive not because it preserves the beloved exactly as they were, but because it doesn’t confuse love with retention. What these scenes imagine is a form of non-selfish love capable of desiring paradise for the loved one’s soul more than proximity for the loved one’s self. If observational collapse is driven

²⁸ Saunders, *Lincoln in the Bardo*, 98.

²⁹ C. S. Lewis, *The Great Divorce* (HarperCollins, 1946).

by the urge to keep the dead fixed and legible, these emissaries model its opposite: a love willing to lose immediate access to the beloved in order to let that beloved become more fully what they might yet be, as part of a greater divine order.

Perhaps, it is fitting now to turn to Dante's *Purgatorio*, a domain where all sinners are simply guilty of excessive love. As Virgil explains:

Hence thou mayst comprehend that love must be
 The seed within yourselves of every virtue,
 And every act that merits punishment.³⁰

This formulation is especially useful because love is not fixed as either a pure virtue or a damnable sin; for Dante, the soul errs not because it loves, but because it loves wrongly. Dante's *Purgatorio* is described as a mountain with seven terraces, each corresponding to a sin. However, unlike its predecessor *Inferno*, the perpetrators of these sins are in Purgatory for a finite amount of time, for however long it will take to "purge" their sins and ascend to *Paradiso*. The seven terraces of Purgatory are organized around excessive love in the following ways: love that is wrongly directed is classified as Pride, Envy, and Wrath; Sloth is the laziness and insufficiency of love for God or true good; and finally, the excessive love for "good" things lies in Avarice, Gluttony, and Lust. Love, then, is not merely an emotion carried into the afterlife that is enacted upon the liminal soul, but the very principle that explains the soul's condition there. Read through Dante, the attachments that bind the dead in other liminal worlds begin to look less like proof of devotion, and more so like evidence of love that has not yet learned how to release or ascend.

³⁰ Dante Alighieri, *Purgatorio*, translated by Henry Wadsworth Longfellow (East India Publishing Company, 2022), 84.

Liminal Transformation

Dante's *Purgatorio* is also a prime setting for transformation in its liminality. On the terrace of Pride, Dante underscores the soul's unfinished condition through an image of metamorphosis:

Do ye not comprehend that we are worms,
Born to bring forth the angelic butterfly
That flieth unto judgment without screen?³¹

Here, the soul is imagined not as fixed, but as a creature in process. The figure of the worm suggests an incomplete, flawed state, while the “angelic butterfly” represents the soul's final purified and elevated form, bound for God and *Paradiso*. This metaphor makes Purgatory's liminality especially clear: its souls exist between what they have been and what they are becoming. They are neither damned nor yet fully beatified, but suspended in a middle state of painful formation and cleansing. The verse also links this transformation to judgment, as the butterfly ultimately “flieth unto judgment,” suggesting that divine evaluation comes not at the beginning of the process but after the soul has been given a chance to be reshaped and redeemed. This is a strong departure from the scenes of immediate divine judgment, as portrayed both by Michelangelo and in Dante's *Inferno*, in which the human soul has no way to account for their known or unknown sins. In this way, *Purgatorio* presents liminality not as a heavenly waiting room, but as the necessary condition for spiritual metamorphosis.

Indeed, *Purgatorio* itself is structured as a mountain and stages this metamorphosis as a process of ascent. The Earthly Paradise lies at its summit. There, Dante meets Beatrice, who draws a personal confession from him. Only after this confrontation with his own moral history can he pass through the final acts of purification. He is immersed in the river Lethe, which

³¹ Ibid., 49

washes away the memory of sin, and then he drinks from the river Eunöe, which restores the memory of good. Dante ends *Purgatorio* with this verse:

From the most holy water I returned
 Regenerate, in the manner of new trees
 That are renewed with a new foliage,
 Pure and disposed to mount unto the stars.³²

This final image completes the poem's larger vision of liminal transformation. Dante does not emerge as the same self merely absolved, but rather as a self truly remade. He is "regenerate," renewed like a tree in fresh leaf, purified and newly prepared for ascent. The two rivers do not simply mark a boundary between one realm and another, but rather, they enact the crossing by altering the one who passes through them. In that sense, this is also a broader truth about liminal spaces, which are not defined only by being between fixed states, but by enabling passage from one state into another. What is that act, then, if not transformation? Rivers, especially, become privileged sites of liminality and occur throughout classic portrayals of redemption and rebirth, a Bardo of nature.

Recall Figure 2, of the scene in *The Last Judgment* where the damned souls cling to Charon's boat before their offloading into Hell. This scene is originally portrayed in Canto III of *Inferno*, with "The demon Charon... gathering them all / And whoso lingers smiteth with his oar."³³ Importantly, after these souls cross "the gloomy waters... And ere upon the further side they land," then the other side of the Acheron river, they rise "anew... gathering a host," suggesting a resurrection of the damned variety.³⁴ The river is thus already a liminal space, but unlike the purifying waters of *Purgatorio*, its transformative quality works in the opposite

³² Ibid., 165

³³ Dante Alighieri, *Inferno*, translated by James Romanes Sibbald, 22.
<https://www.gutenberg.org/cache/epub/41537/pg41537-images.html>.

³⁴ Ibid., 22-23

direction. As Dante descends further, he encounters the Styx river, which grows darker and more corrupted: “In depth of hue the flood did perse excel” as the river becomes “a marsh which by the name of Styx is known.” As the footnotes elucidate, perse “is a colour between purple and black, but the black predominates.”³⁵ This is a fitting aesthetic description for the river that eventually shrinks from a gushing waterway into a muddy swamp. The movement and hue of water here mirrors the moral logic of Hell itself. The Styx muddies rather than cleanses and dries out rather than being renewed and refreshed. Yet this darkening stagnation, too, is transformation. If liminality is defined by its capacity to alter those who pass through it, then the infernal rivers remain liminal even as they produce the opposite of redemption. They harden the soul into the binary judgment it has received.

However, as explored earlier in *Purgatorio*, for those who have not suffered that judgment, water cleanses and lightens the soul for ascent. This is made explicit with:

May we help them wash away their marks
That hence they carried, so that clean and light
They might ascend unto the starry wheels!³⁶

Dante’s rivers therefore reveal that water is never neutral. As a liminal medium, such water enacts transformation in accordance with the moral structure of the realm. It can drag souls downward into filth and fixity, or wash them clean for upward passage. In this way, rivers in classical depictions show us that a liminal space is simply grounds for transformation.

The Reverend in *Lincoln in the Bardo* concludes his character arc by realizing this very fact. After he first perceives the fearsome binary imposed by divine judgment, he is shocked to realize that he is being presented with the feces-encrusted mirror and cruel angelic beings,

³⁵ Ibid., 52

³⁶ Alighieri, *Purgatorio*, 52.

harbingers of his own Hellish destination. He flees from this sight once he knows of this feared destiny, until he returns to the Bardo in which he is “grateful, so deeply grateful” to be back.³⁷ He perceives himself and his fellow inhabitants in the Bardo as rebellious, thinking silently “you shall not be allowed to linger here forever. None of us shall. We are in rebellion against the will of our Lord, and in time must be broken, and go.”³⁸ He believes in the absoluteness of the judgment of this Lord, who sends souls to heaven or hell “according to a standard we are too lowly to discern.” This mentality is strikingly similar to Jonathan Edwards’s sermon, based in the Calvinist doctrine of predestination, both insisting that this system “is only for us to accept,” not to question. However, at the conclusion of the novel, the Reverend finds that this “teaching did not satisfy.”³⁹ He acts against this proclamation, and hence against the “fearsome Lord” at the helm of it, in a moment of “resolve, or defiance.”⁴⁰ He dives into the demonic carapace that is entrapping Willie Lincoln and saves the boy, even with the knowledge that this action will force him to go back to the feared scene of divine judgment he has avoided for so long. The Reverend had stayed in the Bardo because he believed his fate was set beyond his control. In the end though, he abandons that fear and does one last act of good. Importantly, he does not expect this to redeem him, but undertakes it in his resigned state simply because it is right, even if it still damns him. Importantly, the reader never gets to learn what ultimately comes of the Reverend. This withheld ending matters, for Saunders refuses to collapse the Reverend into a final verdict, leaving him instead in a space of moral and narrative uncertainty. The Reverend may be facing a binary divine judgment, but the lack of observation means that, in this case, neither the author nor the reader is the determinant of that.

³⁷ Saunders, *Lincoln in the Bardo*, 193.

³⁸ Ibid, 194

³⁹ Ibid., 268

⁴⁰ Ibid., 268-271

The Reverend's plight is reminiscent of Dylan Thomas's poem "Do not go gentle into that good night." The famed first lines read:

Do not go gentle into that good night,
Old age should burn and rave at close of day;
Rage, rage against the dying of the light.

And follow, later on:

Good men, the last wave by, crying how bright
Their frail deeds might have danced in a green bay,
Rage, rage against the dying of the light.⁴¹

These lines were written by Thomas for his dying father, and can, perhaps, be read as a guilty form of excessive love, as mentioned earlier, a refusal to let a loved one go. In a broader sense, though, they can also be read as sympathetic to the Reverend. Thomas's "frail deeds" are fragile on a cosmic scale in being transient and unable to halt death itself. Yet the poem frames the continued *human* attempt to act, to burn, to resist final closure, as a form of rage against extinction. So does the Reverend with his final act. His rescue of Willie is a frail, but noble, deed, one that cannot undo the larger system of judgment he fears and cannot guarantee his own salvation. But to perform it anyway, in the face of what seems like a predetermined end, is to refuse passivity. It is an assertion of personal agency in the in-between, in the Bardo, a final insistence that the soul can still choose even when it seems already condemned.

C.S. Lewis's words in *The Great Divorce* help name what is at stake in the Reverend's defiance, and in liminal transformation more broadly. When the narrator asks, "is judgement not final? Is there really a way out of Hell into Heaven?," he is answered by an angelic spirit with "It depends on the way ye're using the words. If they leave that grey town behind it will not have

⁴¹ Dylan Thomas, "Do Not Go Gentle into That Good Night," *Poetry Foundation*, <https://www.poetryfoundation.org/poems/46569/do-not-go-gentle-into-that-good-night>.

been Hell. To any that leaves it, it is Purgatory.”⁴² Lewis’s dialogue powerfully echoes Dante’s *Purgatorio*, where the difference between damnation and redemption lies not simply in suffering itself, but in whether suffering still permits transformation. In *Purgatorio*, souls are not yet fixed in their final condition: they climb the mountain, confess and are duly purified by temporary punishment, are cleansed in the rivers, and finally are remade into the “angelic butterfly.”⁴³ Lewis’s words also illuminate the Bardo. For the Reverend, the Bardo first appears as only a temporary holding ground before fixed judgment, but his final act reveals that it could be something closer to Dante’s *Purgatorio*: a liminal space in which the soul can still act beyond fate, where redemption is still possible and attempts at goodness do matter. Across these texts, purgatory becomes the central model for liminality because it names the condition in which the self has not yet been fully closed. What makes a place liminal, then, is not merely that it lies between two destinations, but that within it, transformation remains possible.

Beyond Definition

In the quantum world, Richard Feynman recognized that an electron does not simply travel from point A to point B. Instead, it can simultaneously take every possible path and only collapses into a single trajectory upon observation. As Lightman beautifully summarized, “what we human beings... conceive of as a single reality is actually a tapestry of many simultaneous realities.”⁴⁴ To solve the mathematical issues in earlier quantum theories, Feynman redefined the electron itself to include a cloud of “ghostlike particles” that flicker in and out of existence.⁴⁵ We never encounter the bare electron, always the electron and its inseparable cloud. Attempts to isolate the nature of this fundamental particle dangerously flatten something inherently unstable

⁴² Lewis, *The Great Divorce*, 68.

⁴³ Alighieri, *Purgatorio*, 49.

⁴⁴ Alan Lightman, *A Sense of the Mysterious: Science and the Human Spirit* (New York: Vintage Books, 2005), 129.

⁴⁵ *Ibid.*, 127

and multifaceted, something almost spectral. This is what the underworlds above have already suggested. Their liminal spaces matter because they preserve the conditions for alteration, allowing for dimension without flattening. The Bardo allows the Reverend one final moral act, *Purgatorio* remakes the soul through ascent and cleansing, and even the threshold scenes of Michelangelo and Edwards derive their cultural force from the fact that the soul has not yet been fully fixed. If the dead in these liminal moments resemble anything, they are something closer to Feynman's electron cloud: diffuse, shifting, partly knowable, and always more than the single form that an observer would force it to take.

What if the soul, like a subatomic particle, exists in multiple states until it is observed? This statement harkens back to the favored thought experiment of Schrödinger's cat, simultaneously alive and dead until the box is opened. Perhaps its dilemma lies not in the ambiguity, but in the act of observation itself, the attempt to collapse said ambiguity into certainty. It is not the soul that demands resolution, but the *observer* who cannot bear to exist in uncertainty. Feynman understood this acutely in his personal life as well. Two years after his beloved wife Arline died, he wrote her a letter, placed it in a box, and never opened it again. The letter expresses his refusal to accept her as definitively absent. "I find it hard to understand in my mind what it means to love you after you are dead," he wrote, yet he continued to address her directly with "I want you to love me and care for me."⁴⁶ Arline is gone, and she isn't. Feynman's box becomes a literal version of Schrödinger's – he refuses to give in to the finality of mortal classification, to demand her as either alive and fully his, or dead and beyond connection. Only by leaving the letter unread did he preserve the comforting ambiguity of her simultaneous states. His love remains in superposition, and his box becomes Arline's own Bardo.

⁴⁶ Ibid., 121

Willie's departure from the Bardo offers an alternate version of this ambiguous, unobservable state. He ascends not into heaven or into hell, but into something larger, something free of classification altogether. When Willie finally allows himself to be proclaimed as dead, he does not let this confine him to a single identity or place. Instead of collapsing, Willie expands. Mr. Lincoln realizes that "his boy was gone; his boy was no more... His boy was nowhere; his boy was everywhere."⁴⁷ Willie is "of willie but is no longer (merely) of willie," now surrounded by joy and candy bees and rum punch.⁴⁸ He is Feynman's electron, not observed in isolation, but as part of the shimmering field around him. At this moment, Mr. Lincoln understands. He at last recognizes Willie as "never fixed, nor stable, but always just a passing, temporary energy-burst." He sees, too, that this applies to himself; that he and Willie are "two puffs of smoke [who] became mutually fond."⁴⁹ What are souls, then, if not fixed entities, but brief, loving flashes? Electrons brushing against one another with their ghostly clouds, even just for a minute or a lifetime?

Dylan Thomas captured this abstraction in many of his writings. His poem "And death shall have no dominion" offers a direct challenge to the logic of observational collapse traced across these underworlds. While Edwards imagines the sinner suspended above Hell only until God's will fixes him as damned, and while final judgment scenes such as Michelangelo's or the Reverend's vision convert the soul into a stable verdict, Thomas refuses to grant death that kind of mastery. As he wrote:

And death shall have no dominion.

Dead men naked they shall be one

With the man in the wind and the west moon;

⁴⁷ Saunders, *Lincoln in the Bardo*, 303.

⁴⁸ *Ibid.*, 301

⁴⁹ *Ibid.*, 244

When their bones are picked clean and the clean bones gone,
 They shall have stars at elbow and foot;
 Though they go mad they shall be sane,
 Though they sink through the sea they shall rise again;
 Though lovers be lost love shall not;
 And death shall have no dominion.⁵⁰

Thomas's cosmic imagery reframes death as transformation rather than conclusion. The dead become "one / With the man in the wind and the west moon;" they are no longer sealed within the boundaries of the body or the singular self, but redistributed into a larger continuum of natural being. Even the line "Though lovers be lost love shall not" refuses the possessive logic earlier enacted by Lincoln and Orpheus. Lincoln later realizes this with "When I need to look upon Willie, I will do so in my heart... There where he is yet intact and whole."⁵¹ Love survives not because the beloved remains recoverable in old form, but because such powerful emotion persists beyond ownership and corporeality, beyond time and space. Death, then, does not have dominion because it cannot impose final closure on what continues on, in transformed form, eternally.

Quantum entanglement offers a fitting theoretical framework for this same resistance to isolated definition. In entanglement, the quantum state of one particle cannot be described independently of another particle, even across great distances; Albert Einstein famously called this phenomenon "spooky action at a distance."⁵² The spectral coinage is especially resonant in this thesis. These underworld narratives are populated by ghosts, by lingering souls, by what

⁵⁰ Dylan Thomas, "And death shall have no dominion," *Poets.org*, <https://poets.org/poem/and-death-shall-have-no-dominion>.

⁵¹ Saunders, *Lincoln in the Bardo*, 246.

⁵² Albert Einstein, Max Born, and Hedwig Born, *The Born-Einstein Letters: Correspondence Between Albert Einstein and Max and Hedwig Born from 1916-1955, with Commentaries by Max Born*, translated by Max Born (New York: Macmillan, 1971).

Feynman himself elsewhere imagined as clouds of ghostlike particles flickering in and out of indefinable existence. This is precisely what Saunders's ending suggests during Willie's expansion into "nowhere" and "everywhere."⁵³ He does not persist as a fixed, self-contained unit, but neither does he vanish into nothingness. He simply becomes harder to isolate within the shimmering field into which he disperses. This is also true of love, which does not simply end at the boundary of the body, but continues in a "spooky" attachment of the memories and affections that bind one soul to another. Thomas captures this precisely in the line "Though lovers be lost love shall not," where connection survives even when stable possession does not. Finally, Thomas's natural imagery (sea, stars, flowers, rain, sun) is an example of quantum entanglement at greater scale. The natural world is never still, and electrons are never encountered bare; both are known only in relation and transformation.

Thomas's and Willie's ending words force us to contend that even Saunders's Bardo is not the true form of the liminal underworld. To tarry there too long is its own kind of observational collapse. While it's not the violent binary of heaven and hell, perhaps, the Bardo is still an insistence on remaining in a fixed state, even if that state is a superposition. When Willie finally proclaims himself, and all the others, to be dead, the inhabitants of the Bardo come to understand that they cannot remain suspended forever. "Oh, it was nice," Willie says sadly to his fellow dwellers. "So nice there. But we can't go back. To how we were. All we can do is what we *should*."⁵⁴ The Bardo is liminal and transformative, but it is still a realm organized around the wish to remain near what has already been lost.

⁵³ Ibid., 303

⁵⁴ Ibid., 299

We realize these flaws of the Bardo through a glimpse at Saunders's true afterlife, which is nothing like the divine binary of the Reverend's vision. Willie's language begins to break apart as he goes: "I am Willie I am Willie I am even yet / Am not / Willie / Not willie but somehow / Less / More."⁵⁵ This is true expansion. He continues, "Whatever that former fellow (willie) had, must now be given back... as it never was mine... and therefore is not being taken away, not at all! / As I (who was of willie but is no longer (merely) of willie) return / To such beauty."⁵⁶ What is "given back" here is not merely the self, but the illusion that the self was ever fully separable from the "beauty" of that larger universe from which it originally emerged.

Roger Bevins III's closing meditation makes this vision explicit:

None of it was real; nothing was real. Everything was real; inconceivably real, infinitely dear. These and all things started as nothing, latent within a vast energy-broth, but then we named them, and loved them, and, in this way, brought them forth. And now must lose them.⁵⁷

Here, observation is creative, not oppressive. While naming and loving do bring beings forth, the tragedy begins when naming mistakes itself for ownership, when love mistakes itself for retention. What is brought forth must also be given back to the greater cosmos from which they originally were gifted. As Lincoln finally acknowledges, "All gifts are temporary. I unwillingly surrender this one. And thank you for it. God. Or world."⁵⁸ His love for Willie has been transformed from one of retention to one of acceptance and release. In this sense, Saunders's vision approaches Thomas's eulogizing words that "death shall have no dominion."⁵⁹ Death has no dominion precisely because it cannot keep the soul fixed in one final form. We come "out of

⁵⁵ Ibid., 301

⁵⁶ Ibid., 301

⁵⁷ Ibid., 335

⁵⁸ Ibid., 244

⁵⁹ Thomas, "And death shall have no dominion."

nothingness,” take form, love and are loved, and are “always bound to return to nothingness.”⁶⁰

What seems singular is returned to the larger scale of being, to the wind and west moon, to the “vast energy-broth” from which all things briefly emerge and into which they continue.

(No) Conclusion

I approach the Carroll Crypt, the white stone vault where Willie Lincoln’s dead body found residence for three lonely years. It sits at the far left corner on the back edge of the cemetery, the last in its row. Willie no longer rests here, but a small metal epitaph inside the crypt still memorializes him. It faces the edge of the cliff, the creek running below, and the busy city beyond. From here, you can hear the rush of the water overlaid with the chatter of people walking along the creek. The city is smiling on the first true day of spring. The world is reawakening. Sunlight burns steadily through the frozen heaps of dirty snow. Pink flowers germinate. I try to burn this beautiful moment onto my skin, store it within my heart. It will not stick. None of it will. I can barely feel that spring sun as I write this two weeks later on the cold seventh floor of the stacks, next to cold books about death on a cold shelf a couple of feet from my study carrel.

⁶⁰ Saunders, *Lincoln in the Bardo*, 244.



Figure 3: The Carroll Crypt, Oak Hill Cemetery

The Carroll Crypt (Figure 3) rests with the creek below it and the earth above it. Its roof is covered with soft hilltop grass. It gives the impression of a cave, a brief glimpse into a literal underworld. It is almost part of the earth. Willie is no longer there. The Carroll family lies within

instead, names set into stone shelves. Willie was there, though. Was here. An infinitely loved boy I would never purport to truly know, but with Saunders's words, perhaps I do. A version, at least, of the many possible Willies, and I could not help but love that one. Poor, sweet boy. One of a million poor, sweet children gone too soon and too cruelly.

He is not quite alone, though. Willie's father is there too, in another sense. Pennies rest on the rungs of the iron gate at the crypt's entrance, rusted green but still unmistakably bearing Lincoln's profile. I was moved by their smallness. I hesitate to press the image too far, but I could not help feeling in these pennies some faint suggestion of entanglement, of a ghostly presence persisting through fragments, of one life continuing to flicker towards another. That feeling returns me not only to Saunders's Lincoln, still reaching for Willie, but to Saunders's own understanding of personhood and literature in a recent essay. "Who am I? Everybody," he says, invoking Walt Whitman: "I am large, I contain multitudes." Individuals "within that multitude... flicker on and off" within us; in fact, "this is the idea on which fiction is built."⁶¹

Whitman, the brilliant poet that he is, at last gives me the language for what this thesis has been reaching toward all along.⁶² I want to end, then, by reading "Song of Myself" with him for a moment. Reading is, after all, how so many of us found our way into the humanities in the first place. It is how I learned to start asking these questions and find who I am by briefly becoming entangled with another's words, for to read is to let another consciousness add a multitude to your own. That is the particular power of literature. May we?

⁶¹ George Saunders, "'Could I Understand the People Who Rushed into the Capitol?': George Saunders on How Stories Teach Empathy," *The Guardian*, October 15, 2022. <https://www.theguardian.com/books/2022/oct/15/could-i-understand-the-people-who-rushed-into-the-capitol-george-saunders-on-how-stories-teach-empathy>.

⁶² I must note, of course, that Whitman was deeply affected by Lincoln's death. He turned that grief into some of the most touching tributes in American poetry, with "O Captain! My Captain!" and "When Lilacs Last in the Dooryard Bloom'd" being the most notable elegies.

I celebrate myself, and sing myself,

And what I assume you shall assume,

For every atom belonging to me as good belongs to you.⁶³

The lonely boundaries of the body are refused. Personhood is a shimmering field rather than a stable object. Like Willie becoming “nowhere” and “everywhere,” the self here is distributed, a brief energy-burst always touching other lives. We belong to one another at the level of the atom, quantum entanglement is a romantic waltz.

You shall no longer take things at second or third hand, nor look through the eyes of the dead, nor feed on the spectres in books,

You shall not look through my eyes either, nor take things from me,

You shall listen to all sides and filter them from your self

I have heard what the talkers were talking, the talk of the beginning and the end,

But I do not talk of the beginning or the end.⁶⁴

To “look through the eyes of the dead,” to “feed on the spectres in books” is, in one sense, the method of this thesis. I move through sermons, poems, ghosts, and inherited visions of the afterlife. I borrow partial visions of the dead from the impossible position of the living writer-observer. Koestenbaum would remind us that this format is ontologically unstable, for any attempt to write from the first-person account of the dead is unsubstantiated fiction. Yet Saunders understands this, for *Lincoln in the Bardo* itself is a cataphonic chorus of fractured and unreliable

⁶³ Walt Whitman, “Song of Myself (1892 version),” *Poetry Foundation*.
<https://www.poetryfoundation.org/poems/45477/song-of-myself-1892-version>.

⁶⁴ Ibid.

voices. Whitman's directive, then, is not against reading from another's perspective, but against cannibalizing another life into certainty. To attempt to look fully "through" another person, to "feed" on a defenseless narrative, is itself a kind of collapse. Both the reader, and the human more generally, must instead "listen to all sides" and resist the urge to judge too concretely or summarize too neatly. Truly understanding another person is not, should not be, a period of stasis, an ephemeral glimpse of a limited perspective. We are all connected, "you" and "me."

The sky up there—yet here or next door, or across the way?

The saints and sages in history—but you yourself?

Sermons, creeds, theology—but the fathomless human brain,

And what is reason? and what is love? and what is life?⁶⁵

Whitman does not dismiss saints, sermons, and theology so much as place them beside the deeper mystery they cannot answer. Jonathan Edwards preached of the fear of death and damnation, Michelangelo painted the hope of salvation, but after all these underworlds and judgment scenes, the world after death remains indeed fathomless. The fathomless, by definition, exceeds the bounds of human explanation; what would you call exceeding boundaries if not liminal? This is perhaps as it should be, to drive us back from flawed definition to the fundamental questions tugging at our instinctive cores.

What is known I strip away,

I launch all men and women forward with me into the Unknown.

The clock indicates the moment—but what does eternity indicate?

⁶⁵ Ibid.

...

I know I have the best of time and space, and was never measured and never will be measured.⁶⁶

Whitman breaks the spell of observational collapse and claims a life beyond judgment within “the Unknown.” Just as clocks cannot measure eternity, human viewpoints cannot measure a soul. Against mirrors, scales, feathers, and all the false instruments of divine gaze, he imagines a self that exceeds measure altogether, now and forever.

Do I contradict myself?

Very well then I contradict myself,

(I am large, I contain multitudes.)⁶⁷

In contemplating the unknowable, one person might take comfort in being remembered, another in the surety of predestination, another in the dream state of the Tibetan bardo, another in the hope of eternal salvation, and yet another in the beauty of scientific thought. All of these multitudes are neither right, nor wrong; the outcome is uncertain. I believe we can find reassurance in contradiction, in loving wisely but not too well, in embracing the multitudes, in becoming the marginalia. After all, what are we but one with the west moon, latent within a vast energy-broth, and atoms in the shape of beloved puffs of smoke? I thank your soul for being briefly entangled with mine.

⁶⁶ Ibid.

⁶⁷ Ibid.

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